of the event. Not even opposition parliamentarians asked why US agents were not privy to any inside information. Moreover, Washington did not receive the first news about the sealing off of West Berlin through official channels, their intelligence arrived instead through flashes from American wire service bulletins. It later transpired that no scrambled calls/tap-proof lines were connected between Berlin and Washington on the night of 12-13 August and, astonishingly, the US government received the first comprehensive information about the situation through ARD's Washington correspondent Lothar Loewe, who received his information from colleagues at SFB TV in West Berlin.2

Meanwhile, taking in the unlikely scene unfolding before him, Adam Kellett-Long was astonished at the 'virtual miracle that it had been kept secret in a city alleged to be swarming with spies'.3 As West Berliners stared vacantly at roadblocks, only the more perceptive gawkers may have realised they were witnessing something momentous.

As this was happening, Khrushchev was kept up with developments via phone from the Soviet HQ in Karlshorst. He seemed satisfied. 'I think this earned Honecker great laurels, especially in Moscow,' says Joachim Jauer, then a ZDF correspondent in East Berlin. 'Moscow, of course, was concerned whether this brazen act of cordoning off Berlin would really take place peacefully, that is, without countermeasures by the West.'

By Monday, as the Western powers remained inactive, GDR newspapers treated the Wall as a cause for celebration. Neues Deutschland led with the headline: 'Measures to protect the peace and to secure the German Democratic Republic in force', featuring a photograph of two beaming border guards. What was more, under a sub-heading, 'Normal life in Berlin', the article explained that on Sunday 13 August:

life was completely ordinary, as on all Sundays. The underground traffic ran smoothly and to plan according to the new regulations. Like every Sunday, thousands of Berliners took the S-Bahn out to the countryside. The usual bustle also prevailed at the pavilion of the German travel agency at the